"continuously during the whole flight when we were dark adapted". Separately, a photograph from the Apollo 17 mission showing three dots in a triangular formation low in the lunar sky is now under renewed investigation. According to the Pentagon disclosure, preliminary analysis suggests "the image feature is potentially the result of a physical object in the scene", after years of "no consensus about the nature of the anomaly".

India's Own UFO Mysteries

Reports of unexplained aerial phenomena have surfaced across the world for decades, including in India, where sightings have periodically fuelled speculation, folklore and security concerns. In India, UFO lore is most commonly associated with remote Himalayan regions, particularly Ladakh's Kongka Pass along the Line of Actual Control bordering China, where visibility can stretch across several tens of kilometres owing to exceptionally clear skies.

More recently, however, a 'UFO' incident that sparked widespread concern unfolded in November 2023 at the Imphal airport in Manipur, where commercial flight operations were suspended for nearly three hours after an unidentified white object was seen hovering above the air traffic control tower. A NOTAM (Notice to Air Missions) was subsequently issued, while reports at the time said that two fighter jets had been scrambled as part of the response mechanism. "The object appeared to be of white colour and it moved southwards above ATC Tower and remained stationary there for some time... thereafter disappeared," then minister of state for civil aviation Gen. V.K. Singh (retd) had said in a reply in the Lok Sabha on December 14 that year. The mystery remains unresolved, at least in the public domain.

Jayant Murthy, a Bengaluru-based astrophysicist, believes all UAP sightings ultimately have "good" terrestrial explanations, ranging from natural phenomena to unfamiliar military aircraft. "If anything were to happen now, I would most likely suspect a drone, but maybe it would have been a balloon flight earlier," he says. "There are a lot of phenomena that we don't really have an explanation for, and it's hard to have explanations retroactively."

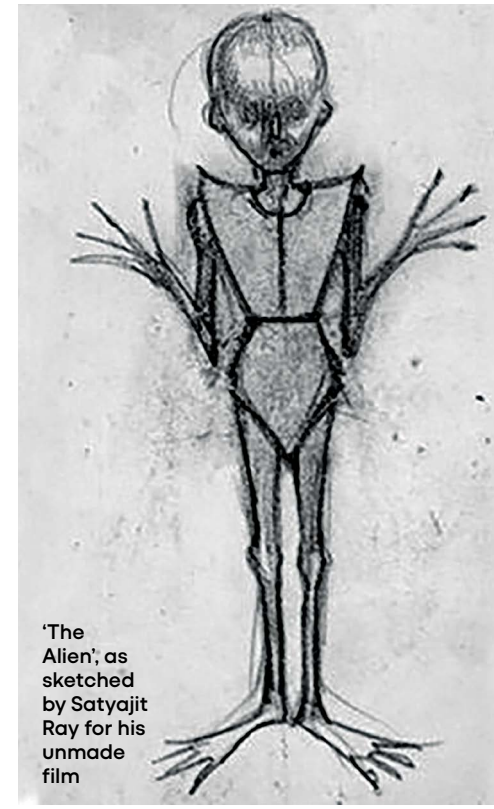
Pentagon's UAP Vault

In the US, such mysteries have evolved from fringe fascination into a subject of official inquiry, backed by military footage and congressional hearings. It was in February that President Donald Trump wrote on Truth Social that, "based on the tremendous interest shown", he was directing the "Secretary of War, and other relevant departments and agencies" to begin releasing files related to "alien and extraterrestrial life, UAP and UFOs"—a move that paved the way for the PURSUE disclosures.

The oldest records date back to 1947, when a national "craze" over "flying discs" or "flying saucers" swept across the US. Archived letters, telegrams and FBI memos from the period show reports pouring in from multiple locations, with one internal US Air Force communication indicating that its intelligence command viewed the phenomena as a matter of concern.

More recent records, particularly from the past decade, include infrared footage of unexplained aerial activity captured by modern sensors aboard military platforms. Among the more curious cases are an eight-pointed flying object recorded over the Middle East in 2013 and footage of a fast-moving object darting between windmills at an undisclosed location in 2024 (see *Close Encounters...*). Heavily redacted to conceal details, the videos were submitted to the All-domain Anomaly Resolution Office (AARO)—an agency established in 2022 under the US Office of the Secretary of Defense to investigate UAP incidents—but there are no answers yet.

Other "compelling" reports in AARO's holdings are based on eyewitness testimony. One of these mentions observations separately reported by seven US federal government employees—including "orange orbs in the sky emit/launch smaller red orbs", a "large, fiery" stationary orb and a "transparent kite"-like object—over two days in 2023 in the western US. Another account concerns a senior US intelligence official observing a "super-hot" orb and other phenomena during helicopter searches near an unnamed military facility.



'The Alien', as sketched by Satyajit Ray for his unmade film

The Scientific Explanation

The disclosures have reignited interest in a question that has fascinated humanity for generations: whether intelligent life exists elsewhere in the universe. Yet scientists studying the material urge caution. "After reviewing the new files, my research team concluded that none of the objects is sufficiently extraordinary to require an exotic origin," says Avi Loeb, a Harvard University astrophysicist who heads the Galileo Project, an initiative engaged in the